

**Subject:** Fw: Decision on submission to Molecular Phylogenetics and Evolution  
**Date:** Thursday, 21 May 2026 at 4:45:53 pm Australian Eastern Standard Time  
**From:** Ian Brennan  
**To:** Scott Keogh, Steve Donnellan, Conrad Hoskin, richards.steve0@gmail.com  
**Attachments:** MPE\_D-25-00545\_review\_final.pdf

Hey folks,

After some serious poking and prodding, MPE has coughed up our reviews for the microhylid paper. Minor revisions seems like a win overall. Comments seem pretty easy to address and are fair.

I'll do my best to get these revisions done ASAP and will send around a new version. Let me know if anyone has any thoughts/worries.

Cheers all.

Ian Brennan  
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**Subject:** Decision on submission to Molecular Phylogenetics and Evolution

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Manuscript Number: **MPE-D-25-00545**

Phylogenomic assessment of microhylid frogs reveals widespread taxonomic confusion in the Asterophryinae and establishes the timing of diversification in Australia

Dear Brennan,

Thank you for submitting your manuscript to Molecular Phylogenetics and Evolution.

I have completed my evaluation of your manuscript. The reviewers recommend reconsideration of your manuscript following minor revision and modification. I invite you to resubmit your manuscript after addressing the comments below. Please resubmit your revised manuscript by **Jun 10, 2026**.

When revising your manuscript, please consider all issues mentioned in the reviewers' comments carefully: please outline every change made in response to their comments and provide suitable rebuttals for any comments not addressed. Please note that a **complete Data Statement** with links to all data analyzed in this study is required; your revised submission may need to be re-reviewed.

To submit your revised manuscript, please log in as an author at <https://www.editorialmanager.com/mpe/>, and navigate to the "Submissions Needing Revision" folder under the Author Main Menu.

Molecular Phylogenetics and Evolution values your contribution and I look forward to receiving your revised manuscript. 

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Kind regards,

Guillermo Orti, Ph.D.

Editor-in-Chief

Molecular Phylogenetics and Evolution

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Editor and Reviewer comments:

Reviewer #1: Please see attached PDF.

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Reviewer #2: It was a pleasure to read this paper that is focused on microhylid frog phylogeny. The quality of the illustrations (including Supplementary Figure 2) is outstanding and complements the solid scientific results very well. I was especially intrigued to see they incorporated statistical analyses of morphological characters of the genera to show that they can be unreliable to assign a given species to genera. The only minor flaw I found with the study, and it is not a fatal one, is that the authors do not cite the important study of Portik et al. (2023) on frog phylogeny: <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ympev.2023.107907>. Results of this latter study have important comparisons to the current one, including other similar comparisons around line 200. Note this passage from the Discussion: "Among asterophryines (Fig. 12), four genera were non-monophyletic: Austrochaperina, Cophixalus, Copiula, and Oreophryne. Hill et al. (2022) also found these genera to be non-monophyletic. Furthermore, our tree showed Oninia as nested within Asterophrys. These results show that the genus-level taxonomy of asterophryines needs revision." It should at least be mentioned in the Intro. The Discussion is well-written and informative, but there were three areas that I thought

could be elaborated a bit more to make the paper of broader interest. The incredible diversification of this group near the Cretaceous-Paleogene boundary is a common theme for other nocturnal vertebrates, including geckos, bats, and other groups of frogs. Could something about this be added to the Discussion? Although oceanic rafting events are known in geckos, iguanian lizards, and other reptile groups, I wonder how rare it is in frogs and how limited the distances might be. Work by Miguel Vences, Breda Zimkus and Rayna Bell provide examples around Africa, including Madagascar. There is also work by several people regarding dispersal of frogs among Asian islands. Last but not least, climate is mentioned only once on line 378. Given the timing of diversification of this group in the Miocene, I wonder if global cooling played a role in changing habitats and creating refugia? Of course if any of this is beyond the scope of the current paper, the authors are free to ignore my suggestions here.

Aside from this, my comments below are quite minor. I hope they are helpful to the authors and I look forward to seeing this paper in print. I do not wish to remain anonymous: Eli Greenbaum

Line 54 and elsewhere in the MS: update to Frost 2026

Line 74: if two new species are going to be mentioned they should probably be listed- I assume these are *Callulops gobakula* Hoskin, 2025 and *Choerophryne koeypad* Hoskin 2025.

Line 131: ensure the past tense is consistent in this paragraph

Line 218: and should not be in italics and there seems to be a grammatical error at the end of the sentence that makes its meaning confusing

Line 222: well-defined here, and in other areas of the MS, well-supported

Line 239: Fig.3 should be Fig. 3.

Line 246: third-largest

Line 340: which study identified the *Oreophryne* 'B' clade?

Line 344: this should be Dubois 2021

Line 421: best to not start a sentence with a number

Figure 1: the authors might consider adding scale bars to the maps so that relative distances can be assessed

Figure 2: I see *Sphenophryne thomsoni* is listed with a slash as "Geny", I assume, *Genyophryne*. I realize the taxonomic placement of this species is problematic when I look at the tree, but could the authors add a brief explanation to the caption to avoid confusion about this?

Figure 3: Latin names should be in italics

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## Reviewer's Responses to Questions

Note: In order to effectively convey your recommendations for improvement to the author(s), and help editors make well-informed and efficient decisions, we ask you to answer the following specific questions about the manuscript and provide additional suggestions where appropriate.

1. Are the objectives and the rationale of the study clearly stated?

Please provide suggestions to the author(s) on how to improve the clarity of the objectives and rationale of the study. Please number each suggestion so that author(s) can more easily respond.

Reviewer #1: Yes. Please see attached PDF for further commentary.

Reviewer #2: Yes

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2. If applicable, is the method/study reported in sufficient detail to allow for its replicability and/or reproducibility?

Please provide suggestions to the author(s) on how to improve the replicability/reproducibility of their study. Please number each suggestion so that the author(s) can more easily respond.

Reviewer #1: Mark as appropriate with an X:

Yes ☐ No ☒ N/A ☐

Provide further comments here:

Please see attached PDF.

Reviewer #2: Mark as appropriate with an X:

Yes ☒ No ☐ N/A ☐

Provide further comments here:

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3. If applicable, are statistical analyses, controls, sampling mechanism, and statistical reporting (e.g., P-values, CIs, effect sizes) appropriate and well described?

Please clearly indicate if the manuscript requires additional peer review by a statistician. Kindly provide suggestions to the author(s) on how to improve the statistical analyses, controls, sampling mechanism, or statistical reporting. Please number each suggestion so that the author(s) can more easily respond.

Reviewer #1: Mark as appropriate with an X:

Yes ☒ No ☐ N/A ☐

Provide further comments here: Please see attached PDF for further commentary.

Reviewer #2: Mark as appropriate with an X:

Yes ☒ No ☐ N/A ☐

Provide further comments here:

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4. Could the manuscript benefit from additional tables or figures, or from improving or removing (some of the) existing ones?

Please provide specific suggestions for improvements, removals, or additions of figures or tables. Please number each suggestion so that author(s) can more easily respond.

Reviewer #1: Yes. Please see attached PDF.

Reviewer #2: I think it is appropriate as is

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5. If applicable, are the interpretation of results and study conclusions supported by the data?

Please provide suggestions (if needed) to the author(s) on how to improve, tone down, or expand the study interpretations/conclusions. Please number each suggestion so that the author(s) can more easily respond.

Reviewer #1: Mark as appropriate with an X:

Yes ☐ No ☒ N/A ☐

Provide further comments here:

Mostly supported but we have suggested a few ways to improve the interpretations. Please see attached PDF.

Reviewer #2: Mark as appropriate with an X:

Yes ☒ No ☐ N/A ☐

Provide further comments here:

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6. Have the authors clearly emphasized the strengths of their study/methods?

Please provide suggestions to the author(s) on how to better emphasize the strengths of their study. Please number each suggestion so that the author(s) can more easily respond.

Reviewer #1: Yes.

Reviewer #2: Yes

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7. Have the authors clearly stated the limitations of their study/methods?

Please list the limitations that the author(s) need to add or emphasize. Please number each limitation so that author(s) can more easily respond.

Reviewer #1: Mostly. Please see attached PDF.

Reviewer #2: Yes they do this clearly in the Discussion

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8. Does the manuscript structure, flow or writing need improving (e.g., the addition of subheadings, shortening of text, reorganization of sections, or moving details from one section to another)?

Please provide suggestions to the author(s) on how to improve the manuscript structure and flow. Please number each suggestion so that author(s) can more easily respond.

Reviewer #1: No, only minor improvements necessary. Please see attached PDF.

Reviewer #2: Overall I think it is fine

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9. Could the manuscript benefit from language editing?

Reviewer #1: No

Reviewer #2: No

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